capacity of democracy in Asia for economic achievement for the people." The embassy proposed a five-year $500 million economic and $300 million food assistance package to ensure India's success and to show that the US did not just rely on a military approach.[5] India's ambitious $14.7 billion second five-year plan, which envisioned more than double the expenditure of the first five-year plan, left the country in need of food assistance and with a critical foreign exchange gap of $1.7 billion.[6] The plan, which began in spring 1956, offered the US an opportunity to assist India. Subsequently, a State Department task force established by Dulles suggested a $75 million annual aid package for India for five years, as well as $300 million of food aid via the new Food for Peace, or PL-480, program.

A key challenge remained: convincing Congress. Within the administration, advocates like Dulles wanted the US to move toward a more flexible and imaginative aid policy. Skeptics like Treasury Secretary George Humphrey, however, cautioned that there was little appetite on Capitol Hill for long-term assistance, especially for India. Representative Robert Byrd (D-WV) indeed predicted a "sufficiently hard time" for appropriating even a one-year commitment for the country through Congress.[7]

In spring 1956 hearings on the administration's foreign assistance request, officials tried to convince members of Congress that it was crucial to aid India. They highlighted for various committees the significance of the demonstrative effect of its success vis-à-vis China. One official, for example, stated, "The people of Asia are watching the show windows of Communist China and India.… It is in the interests of the free world that India provide the more genuinely successful example."[8] And India, officials argued, would not succeed without American aid. If India failed, like Nationalist China had before it, all of Asia would likely fall to communism. Thus, Dulles, Cooper, and others asserted that the US had an interest in preventing Indian failure and even ensuring an Indian victory versus China.

Officials and advocates highlighted India's achievements, adding that American aid had already had an impact. They noted that India's progress had been modest, but nonetheless remarkable. Dulles also assured members of Congress that Nehru was "fighting the Communists very hard in India" and trying to "avoid being absorbed into the Communist bloc." Other officials played up Chinese and Soviet economic engagement with India.[9] Eisenhower, on his part, publicly warned of the communists "falsely